UX AUDIT CASE STUDIES

Pinterest · Amazon

Sruthi S · UI/UX Designer · sruthismanian@gmail.com · linkedin.com/in/sruthisubramanian06 · Behance Portfolio

Why these two products?
I chose Pinterest and Amazon because I use both daily — and kept noticing moments of friction I couldn't ignore. Instead of reacting as a user, I decided to observe as a designer. These audits were an exercise in diagnosing *why* something feels off, not just *that* it does. I applied Nielsen's 10 Usability Heuristics and a 7-question UX observation framework throughout.

01 — Pinterest UX Redesign

UX Audit · Mobile Redesign · Information Architecture · Day 3 of #30DayUXChallenge

THE PROBLEM I NOTICED

Pinterest is a discovery app — its entire value is helping you find things you didn't know you were looking for. But the original layout hid the search bar behind a bottom-tab icon that looked identical to other navigation items. As a user, I kept missing it. As a designer, I wanted to understand why a discovery-first app would bury its most important action.

WHAT I OBSERVED

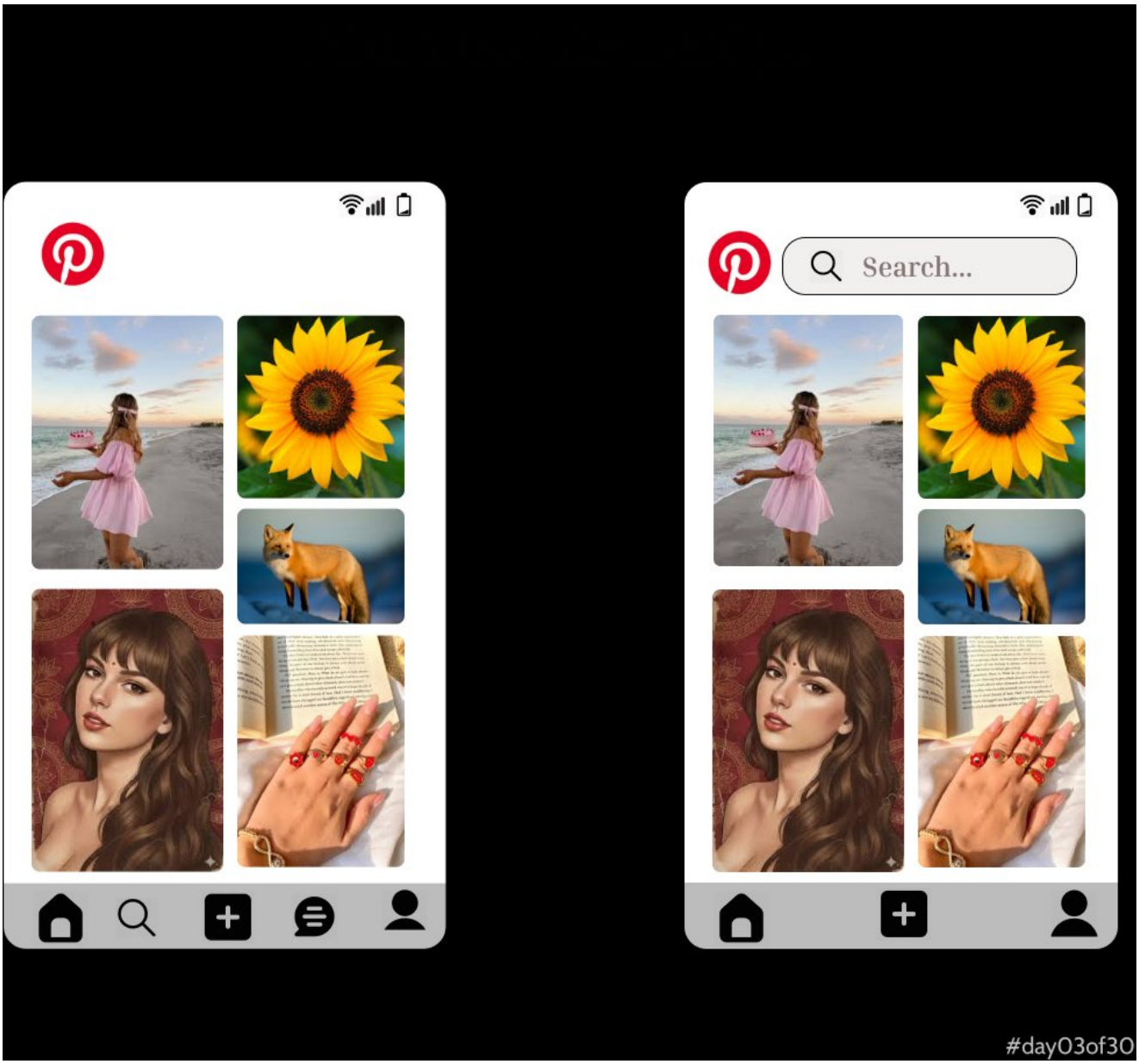
1. **Search was invisible** — The search icon in the bottom nav blended with Home, Add, and Profile — no visual hierarchy differentiated its importance
2. **Content overload on home** — The masonry feed had no breathing room — pins stacked with inconsistent spacing made it hard to know where to look
3. **Redundant navigation items** — A separate 'Messages' tab occupied prime nav space despite low usage frequency for a content browsing app
4. **No search affordance on the home screen** — Users had to already know to tap the magnifier — there was no persistent prompt or search bar visible at a glance

MY FIX

I moved the search bar to the top of the home screen — visible immediately on app open, before any scrolling. I also cleaned up the bottom navigation by removing the redundant Messages tab and consolidating to the four actions users actually use: Home, Create, and Profile. This reduces cognitive load and puts discovery — Pinterest's core job — front and centre.

WHAT I LEARNT

Placement is a design decision, not an afterthought. Where you put a feature tells the user how important it is. Pinterest's original layout was sending the wrong signal about its own core value. The redesign wasn't about adding anything new — it was about making the existing purpose clearer.



Before (left) vs After (right) — Search moved to top, nav simplified, visual hierarchy improved

---

02 — Amazon UX Audit

Heuristic Evaluation · Checkout Flow · 6 Friction Points · Day 7 of #30DayUXChallenge

WHY AMAZON'S CHECKOUT BOTHERED ME

Amazon is the world's largest e-commerce platform — and yet I've abandoned my cart there more times than anywhere else. Not because I changed my mind, but because the checkout flow created anxiety: unclear feedback, confusing address labels, and a payment screen that left me wondering if my order had actually gone through. I decided to document every friction point across one complete checkout journey using the 7-question UX observation framework.

6 FRICTION POINTS I FOUND

1. **Irrelevant ads in search results** — Sponsored products appeared above exact-match results — business goals overriding user intent, a classic dark pattern

2. **Search relevance failure** — Searching 'wired headphones' surfaced wireless results prominently — the algorithm ignored explicit user filters

3. **Unclear cart quantity feedback** — Adding an item showed no clear confirmation of how many units were now in the cart — users had to navigate away to verify

4. **Slow image loading creates anxiety** — Product images loaded with visible delay — perceived performance affects trust, even if the actual speed is acceptable

5. **Address section requires thinking twice** — Shipping address labels ('Default', 'Home', an address string) forced re-reading before selecting — low label clarity

6. **Payment interrupted — order status unknown** — After confirming payment, there was no immediate 'Order Confirmed' screen — users were left in a state of uncertainty

MY PROPOSED FIX

The highest-impact change is the simplest: add a clear 'Order Confirmed' state immediately after payment. One screen, order number visible, estimated delivery shown. This single fix addresses the most stressful moment in the entire flow. For the address section, replacing ambiguous labels with clear descriptors ('Deliver here · Home') reduces hesitation. For search, showing a filter-active state when results are being constrained would restore user trust.

WHAT I LEARNT

The most surprising finding was that Amazon's friction isn't accidental — most of it is deliberate (ads, algorithm-pushed sponsored products). This taught me that UX design in the real world is always negotiating between user needs and business goals. Understanding that tension is as important as knowing how to fix the interface.

6 friction points documented during a live checkout audit — applied the 7-question UX observation framework

Sruthi S · UI/UX Designer · sruthismanian@gmail.com · linkedin.com/in/sruthisubramanian06
More work on Behance · Figma prototype: Calmora App